government's tenure. Meanwhile, another former CM, H.D. Kumaraswamy of the JD(S), accused the government of narrowing down the scope of the Yuvanidhi unemployment allowance scheme by restricting it to passouts in 2022-23.

As the five guarantees are being launched midway through the current financial year, Siddaramaiah estimates it will require over Rs 40,000 crore this fiscal to implement them. The details, it is expected, will be spelt out in July when the CM presents a fresh state budget.

The state's tax revenues will amount to Rs 1.64 lakh crore in 2023-24, according to the vote-on-account presented in February. While Karnataka's economy grew at 7.9 per cent in FY23, the state's tax revenues benefitted from higher GST collections, increase in vehicle sales and revival of the real estate sector, noted Karnataka's Medium Term Fiscal Plan 2023-27 which was tabled in the assembly this February.

Of the state's taxes, the largest share comes from commercial taxes—including GST compensation—at Rs 97,000 crore (59 per cent), followed by excise revenue from liquor at Rs 35,000 crore (21 per cent), stamps and registration at Rs 19,000 crore (12 per cent) and motor vehicle tax at Rs 10,500 crore (6 per cent), besides other heads, which contribute Rs 3,153 crore (2 per cent). According to a senior official, the government will also have some headroom for borrowings considering that the current estimate of GSDP for FY24, at Rs 25. 7 lakh crore, is higher than the earlier projection of Rs 23.3 lakh crore.

"It's not about how much money you are spending, but who you are spending it on," Siddaramaiah said on June 11 at the launch of the Shakti free bus travel scheme, citing World Bank statistics to show that the labour force participation rate among females in India, at 24 per cent, was lower than even Bangladesh and Indonesia. "We want to empower the weaker sections," he said, adding that four of the five Congress guarantees are linked to empowering women.

THE 5 GUARANTEES

The Congress had five pre-poll promises that will together cost the exchequer ***Rs 59,000 cr. annually***



SHAKTI
Free travel for women within Karnataka on state transport buses (excluding premium services) was rolled out on June 11; **4.2 million** beneficiaries daily. Cost: **₹4,052 crore** annually*



ANNA BHAGYA
10 kg foodgrains per month for ration card holders, starting July 1. It'll help some **11.3 million** BPL families. Annual cost: **₹10,100 crore**



GRUHA JYOTHI
Free power for domestic consumers whose monthly usage is less than 200 units from August 1. Some **21.4 million** households will avail this benefit. Yearly cost: **₹13,000 crore**



GRUHA LAKSHMI
Monthly allowance of Rs 2,000 to every family headed by a woman (excluding tax payers) from mid-August. It'll empower **12.8 million**. Cost: **₹30,000 crore** a year



YUVANIDHI
For two years, monthly allowance of Rs 3,000 for graduates, Rs 1,500 for diploma-holders of 2023 batch, who are jobless even after six months. Date yet to be announced. **400,000** to benefit. Cost: **₹2,000 crore** a year

**No. of beneficiaries and cost are estimated figures*

Ensuring a smooth roll-out of these schemes poses as much a challenge as raising resources—each scheme will require beneficiaries to enrol either through the Seva Sindhu e-governance portal or physically via help desks. At a high-level meeting last week, Siddaramaiah instructed officials to ramp up the capacity of the Seva Sindhu portal to handle the huge amount of data expected, while also ensuring that the application process is kept simple.

> **"IT'S NOT ABOUT HOW MUCH MONEY YOU ARE SPENDING, BUT WHO YOU ARE SPENDING IT ON"**
>
> **–SIDDARAMAIAH**
> Karnataka CM

A senior official explains that the portal, which handled around 10,000 applications per day last year for various services, is likely to process up to 1-1.5 million applications related to the five guarantees when enrolment opens up. The online application procedure, which is being finalised, will also do away with the need to upload documents, he added. Meanwhile, on June 14, Siddaramaiah accused the Centre of trying to stall the Anna Bhagya scheme's imminent rollout on July 1—the trigger for this was the recent decision to discontinue the sale of wheat and rice to state governments under the Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic) and offload stocks via e-auctions in a bid to cool down rising prices. Having worked out a blueprint for its five big promises, the Siddaramaiah government now has its hands full with the task of delivering them. ■